Labour: Being Human Again—"Wages of Labour" and "Estranged Labour" in the Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844

Work as physical or mental labour takes up a large part of an adult's life. But what makes work itself meaningful? What kind of work life is worth living?

In "Wages of Labour" (WL) and "Estranged Labour" (EL; also translated as "Alienated Labour"), Karl Marx argues that human beings at work should find themselves free and spontaneous. When labouring, we are in a state of well-being and self-fulfillment by being conscious of ourselves and at the same time, of our being members of the human community. We are also conscious of being part of nature, and our ability to engage with it as a material to work on and an object for thinking beyond our physical needs.

Marx's ideal, however, is quite far from the reality workers faced. Division of labour in factories was widespread and intense in Europe when the manuscripts were written. While Adam Smith believes that this mode of manufacture promotes wealth for all, Marx sees in the division of labour a mechanism for the oppression and systematic brutalization of the worker. Capitalists accumulate social power with their wealth whereas workers keep struggling to find buyers for their labour. They have to put up with long working hours and they suffer from premature death. Marx calls this "estrangement" (or "alienation") of the worker, the central concept in our reading.

Marx argues that there are four ways that workers are estranged. First, they do not recognize the products they make in that they do not own them and in face of the world of objects they produce, they see not their lives but a hostile enemy. Second, they are forced to produce for capitalists; the activity of labour becomes a system of coercion. Third, they are estranged from their essential humanity—in

performing this labour, they act not as human beings but as machines. Lastly, they are estranged from others because they encounter fellow humans only as workers, not as free and whole beings. When we are estranged, we cannot actualize ourselves as human beings.

As a strong believer of equality, Marx advocated radical social change. *The Communist Manifesto*, written by Marx and his life long friend Friedrich Engels (1820–1895), was published in 1848. It is a vehement attack on the way the bourgeoisie (or ruling class that took power from the aristocrats) exploit the proletariat (or property-less working class). The manifesto places a greater emphasis on analyzing the separation of human beings into classes in the history of human society, addressing workers directly at times, and calling them to action. Our reading from the earlier Marx employs a similar style of expression, but it focuses more on the reason for Marx's call for revolution: the dehumanization imposed on the worker by the conditions of production in bourgeois society.

"Wages of Labour" and "Estranged Labour" were originally collected in the *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844* or *Paris Manuscripts*, fully published in 1932. Many of the ideas were to become the monumental *Das Kapital, Volume I* (or, in English, *Capital, Volume I*), itself a product of Marx's own labour.

Our reading is selected because of the way much of the phenomena described by Marx still rings true in contemporary societies. As our syllabus comes to a close, these manuscripts address yet again the central question running through the course: how to live well as individuals among others.

Our translation is by Rodney Livingstone and Gregor Benton from *Early Writings*. We made our selection with reference to the Chicago Great Books Foundation selection.

Yeung Yang

from

Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844

by Karl Marx

WAGES OF LABOUR

Wages are determined by the fierce struggle between capitalist and worker. The 1
capitalist inevitably wins. The capitalist can live longer without the worker than the worker can without him. Combination among capitalists is habitual and effective, while combination among the workers is forbidden and has painful consequences for them. In addition to that, the landowner and the capitalist can increase their revenues with the profits of industry, while the worker can supplement his income from industry with neither ground rent nor interest on capital. This is the reason for the intensity of competition among the workers. It is therefore only for the worker that the separation of capital, landed property and labour is a necessary, essential and pernicious separation. Capital and landed property need not remain constant in this abstraction, as must the labour of the workers.

So for the worker the separation of capital, ground rent and labour is fatal. 2

From Karl Marx, "Wages of Labour", "Estranged Labour", translated by Rodney Livingstone and Gregor Benton in *Early Writings*, published by Penguin Books in association with New Left Review, London 1995. Reproduced by permission of New Left Review.

3 For wages the lowest and the only necessary rate is that required for the subsistence of the worker during work and enough extra to support a family and prevent the race of workers from dying out. According to Smith, the normal wage is the lowest which is compatible with common humanity, i.e. with a bestial existence.[1]

4 *The demand for men necessarily regulates the production of men, as of every other commodity.* If the supply greatly exceeds the demand, then one section of the workers sinks into beggary or starvation. The existence of the worker is therefore reduced to the same condition as the existence of every other commodity. The worker has become a commodity, and he is lucky if he can find a buyer. And the demand on which the worker's life depends is regulated by the whims of the wealthy and the capitalists. If supply exceeds demand, one of the elements which go to make up the price—profit, ground rent, wages—will be paid below its *price*. A part of these elements is therefore withdrawn from this application, with the result that the market price gravitates towards the natural price as the central point. But (1) it is very difficult for the worker to direct his labour elsewhere where there is a marked division of labour; and (2) because of his subordinate relationship to the capitalist, he is the first to suffer.

5 *So the worker is sure to lose and to lose most from the gravitation of the market price towards the natural price.* And it is precisely the ability of the capitalist to direct his capital elsewhere which either drives the worker, who is restricted to one particular branch of employment, into starvation or forces him to submit to all the capitalist's demands.

6 The sudden chance fluctuations in market price hit ground rent less than that part of the price which constitutes profit and wages, but they hit profit less than wages. For every wage which rises, there is generally one which remains *stationary* and another which *falls*.

7 *The worker does not necessarily gain when the capitalist gains, but he necessarily loses with him.* For example, the worker does not gain if the capitalist keeps the market price above the natural price by means of a manufacturing or trade secret, a monopoly or a favourably placed property.

8 Moreover, *the prices of labour are much more constant than the prices of provisions*. They are often in inverse proportion. In a dear year, wages drop because

[1] Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, 2 vols., Everyman edition, Vol. I, p. 61.

of a drop in demand and rise because of an increase in the price of provisions. They therefore balance. In any case, some workers are left without bread. In cheap years wages rise on account of the rise in demand and fall on account of the fall in the price of provisions. So they balance.[2]

Another disadvantage for the worker: 9

The price of the labour of different kinds of workers varies much more than the 10
profits of the various branches in which capital is put to use. In the case of labour, all the natural, spiritual and social variations in individual activity are manifested and variously rewarded, whereas dead capital behaves in a uniform way and is indifferent to *real* individual activity.

In general, we should note that where worker and capitalist both suffer, the 11
worker suffers in his very existence while the capitalist suffers in the profit on his dead mammon.

The worker has not only to struggle for his physical means of subsistence; he 12
must also struggle for work, i.e. for the possibility and the means of realizing his activity.

Let us consider the three main conditions which can occur in society and their 13
effect on the worker.

(1) If the wealth of society is decreasing, the worker suffers most, for although 14
the working class cannot gain as much as the property owners when society is prospering, *none suffers more cruelly from its decline than the working class*.[3]

(2) Let us now consider a society in which wealth is increasing. This condition 15
is the only one favourable to the worker. Here competition takes place among the capitalists. The demand for workers outstrips supply. But:

In the first place the rise in wages leads to *overwork* among the workers. The 16
more they want to earn the more they must sacrifice their time and freedom and work like slaves in the service of avarice. In doing so they shorten their lives. But this is all to the good of the working class as a whole, since it creates a renewed demand. This class must always sacrifice a part of itself if it is to avoid total destruction.

Furthermore, when is a society in a condition of increasing prosperity? When 17
the capitals and revenues of a country are growing. But this is only possible

[2] Smith, op. cit., I, pp. 76–7.

[3] ibid., p. 230.

18 (a) as a result of the accumulation of a large quantity of labour, for capital is accumulated labour; that is to say, when more and more of the worker's products are being taken from him, when his own labour increasingly confronts him as alien property and the means of his existence and of his activity are increasingly concentrated in the hands of the capitalist.

19 (b) The accumulation of capital increases the division of labour, and the division of labour increases the number of workers; conversely, the growth in the number of workers increases the division of labour, just as the growth in the division of labour increases the accumulation of capital. As a consequence of this division of labour on the one hand and the accumulation of capitals on the other, the worker becomes more and more uniformly dependent on labour, and on a particular, very one-sided and machine-like type of labour. Just as he is depressed, therefore, both intellectually and physically to the level of a machine, and from being a man becomes an abstract activity and a stomach, so he also becomes more and more dependent on every fluctuation in the market price, in the investment of capital and in the whims of the wealthy. Equally, the increase in that class of men who do nothing but work increases the competition among the workers and therefore lowers their price. In the factory system conditions such as these reach their climax.

20 (c) In a society which is becoming increasingly prosperous, only the very richest can continue to live from the interest on money. All the rest must run a business with their capital, or put it on the market. As a result the competition among the capitalists increases, there is a growing concentration of capital, the big capitalists ruin the small ones and a section of the former capitalists sinks into the class of the workers which, because of this increase in numbers, suffers a further depression of wages and becomes even more dependent on the handful of big capitalists. Because the number of capitalists has fallen, competition for workers hardly exists any longer, and because the number of workers has increased, the competition among them has become all the more considerable, unnatural and violent. Hence a section of the working class is reduced to beggary or starvation with the same necessity as a section of the middle capitalists ends up in the working class.

21 So even in the state of society most favourable to him, the inevitable consequence for the worker is overwork and early death, reduction to a machine, enslavement to capital which piles up in threatening opposition to him, fresh competition and starvation or beggary for a section of the workers.

22 An increase in wages arouses in the worker the same desire to get rich as in the capitalist, but he can only satisfy this desire by sacrificing his mind and his body. An increase in wages presupposes, and brings about, the accumulation of capital, and thus opposes the product of labour to the worker as something increasingly alien to him. Similarly, the division of labour makes him more and more one-sided and dependent, introducing competition from machines as well as from men. Since the worker has been reduced to a machine, the machine can confront him as a competitor. Finally, just as the accumulation of capital increases the quantity of industry and therefore the number of workers, so it enables the same quantity of industry to produce a *greater quantity of products*. This leads to overproduction and ends up either by putting a large number of workers out of work or by reducing their wages to a pittance.

23 Such are the consequences of a condition of society which is most favourable to the worker, i.e. a condition of *growing* wealth.

24 But in the long run the time will come when this state of growth reaches a peak. What is the situation of the worker then?

25 (3) 'In a country which had acquired that full complement of riches ... both the wages of labour and the profits of stock would probably be very low ... the competition for employment would necessarily be so great as to reduce the wages of labour to what was barely sufficient to keep up the number of labourers, and, the country being already fully peopled, that number could never be augmented.'[4]

26 The surplus population would have to die.

27 So in a declining state of society we have the increasing misery of the worker; in an advancing state, complicated misery; and in the terminal state, static misery.

28 Smith tells us that a society of which the greater part suffers is not happy.[5] But since even the most prosperous state of society leads to suffering for the majority and since the economic system [*Nationalökonomie*], which is a society based on private interests, brings about such a state of prosperity, it follows that society's distress is the goal of the economic system.

[...]

[4] ibid., p. 84.

[5] ibid., p. 70.

ESTRANGED LABOUR

29 We have started out from the premises of political economy. We have accepted its language and its laws. We presupposed private property; the separation of labour, capital and land, and likewise of wages, profit and capital; the division of labour; competition; the concept of exchange value, etc. From political economy itself, using its own words, we have shown that the worker sinks to the level of a commodity, and moreover the most wretched commodity of all; that the misery of the worker is in inverse proportion to the power and volume of his production [...].

30 Political economy proceeds from the fact of private property. It does not explain it. It grasps the *material* process of private property, the process through which it actually passes, in general and abstract formulae which it then takes as *laws*. It does not *comprehend* these laws, i.e. it does not show how they arise from the nature of private property. Political economy fails to explain the reason for the division between labour and capital, between capital and land. For example, when it defines the relation of wages to profit it takes the interests of the capitalists as the basis of its analysis; i.e. it assumes what it is supposed to explain. Similarly, competition is frequently brought into the argument and explained in terms of external circumstances. Political economy teaches us nothing about the extent to which these external and apparently accidental circumstances are only the expression of a necessary development. We have seen how exchange itself appears to political economy as an accidental fact. The only wheels which political economy sets in motion are *greed* and the *war of the avaricious—competition*.

[...]

31 We must avoid repeating the mistake of the political economist, who bases his explanations on some imaginary primordial condition. Such a primordial condition explains nothing. It simply pushes the question into the grey and nebulous distance. It assumes as facts and events what it is supposed to deduce, namely the necessary relationship between two things, between, for example, the division of labour and exchange. Similarly, theology explains the origin of evil by the fall of man, i.e. it assumes as a fact in the form of history what it should explain.

32 We shall start out from a *present-day* economic fact.

33 The worker becomes poorer the more wealth he produces, the more his production increases in power and extent. The worker becomes an ever cheaper

commodity the more commodities he produces. The *devaluation* of the human world grows in direct proportion to the *increase in value* of the world of things. Labour not only produces commodities; it also produces itself and the workers as a *commodity* and it does so in the same proportion in which it produces commodities in general.

34 This fact simply means that the object that labour produces, its product, stands opposed to it as *something alien*, as a *power independent* of the producer. The product of labour is labour embodied and made material in an object, it is the *objectification* of labour. The realization of labour is its objectification. In the sphere of political economy this realization of labour appears as a *loss of reality* for the worker, objectification as *loss of and bondage to the object*, and appropriation as *estrangement*, as *alienation* [*Entäusserung*].

35 So much does the realization of labour appear as loss of reality that the worker loses his reality to the point of dying of starvation. So much does objectification appear as loss of the object that the worker is robbed of the objects he needs most not only for life but also for work. Work itself becomes an object which he can only obtain through an enormous effort and with spasmodic interruptions. So much does the appropriation of the object appear as estrangement that the more objects the worker produces the fewer can he possess and the more he falls under the domination of his product, of capital.

36 All these consequences are contained in this characteristic, that the worker is related to the *product of his labour* as to an *alien* object. For it is clear that, according to this premise, the more the worker exerts himself in his work, the more powerful the alien, objective world becomes which he brings into being over against himself, the poorer he and his inner world become, and the less they belong to him. It is the same in religion. The more man puts into God, the less he retains within himself. The worker places his life in the object; but now it no longer belongs to him, but to the object. The greater his activity, therefore, the fewer objects the worker possesses. What the product of his labour is, he is not. Therefore, the greater this product, the less is he himself. The externalization [*Entäusserung*] of the worker in his product means not only that his labour becomes an object, an *external* existence, but that it exists *outside him*, independently of him and alien to him, and begins to confront him as an autonomous power; that the life which he has bestowed on the object confronts him as hostile and alien.

37 Let us now take a closer look at *objectification*, at the production of the worker, and the *estrangement*, the *loss* of the object, of his product, that this entails.

38 The worker can create nothing without *nature*, without the *sensuous external world*. It is the material in which his labour realizes itself, in which it is active and from which and by means of which it produces.

39 But just as nature provides labour with the *means of life* in the sense that labour cannot *live* without objects on which to exercise itself, so also it provides the *means of life* in the narrower sense, namely the means of physical subsistence of the *worker*.

40 The more the worker *appropriates* the external world, sensuous nature, through his labour, the more he deprives himself of the *means of life* in two respects: firstly, the sensuous external world becomes less and less an object belonging to his labour, a *means of life* of his labour; and secondly, it becomes less and less a *means of life* in the immediate sense, a means for the physical subsistence of the worker.

41 In these two respects, then, the worker becomes a slave of his object; firstly in that he receives an *object of labour*, i.e. he receives work, and secondly in that he receives *means of subsistence*. Firstly, then, so that he can exist as a *worker*, and secondly as a *physical subject*. The culmination of this slavery is that it is only as a *worker* that he can maintain himself as a *physical subject* and only as a *physical subject* that he is a worker.

42 (The estrangement of the worker in his object is expressed according to the laws of political economy in the following way: the more the worker produces, the less he has to consume; the more values he creates, the more worthless he becomes; the more his product is shaped, the more misshapen the worker; the more civilized his object, the more barbarous the worker; the more powerful the work, the more powerless the worker; the more intelligent the work, the duller the worker and the more he becomes a slave of nature.)

43 *Political economy conceals the estrangement in the nature of labour by ignoring the direct relationship between the worker* (labour) *and production*. It is true that labour produces marvels for the rich, but it produces privation for the worker. It produces palaces, but hovels for the worker. It produces beauty, but deformity for the worker. It replaces labour by machines, but it casts some of the workers back into barbarous forms of labour and turns others into machines. It produces intelligence, but it produces idiocy and cretinism for the worker.

44 *The direct relationship of labour to its products is the relationship of the worker to the objects of his production*. The relationship of the rich man to the objects of production and to production itself is only a *consequence* of this first relationship, and confirms it. Later we shall consider this second aspect. Therefore when we ask what is the essential relationship of labour, we are asking about the relationship of the worker to production.

45 Up to now we have considered the estrangement, the alienation of the worker only from one aspect, i.e. his *relationship to the products of his labour*. But estrangement manifests itself not only in the result, but also in the *act of production*, within the *activity of production* itself. How could the product of the worker's activity confront him as something alien if it were not for the fact that in the act of production he was estranging himself from himself? After all, the product is simply the résumé of the activity, of the production. So if the product of labour is alienation, production itself must be active alienation, the alienation of activity, the activity of alienation. The estrangement of the object of labour merely summarizes the estrangement, the alienation in the activity of labour itself.

46 What constitutes the alienation of labour?

47 Firstly, the fact that labour is *external* to the worker, i.e. does not belong to his essential being; that he therefore does not confirm himself in his work, but denies himself, feels miserable and not happy, does not develop free mental and physical energy, but mortifies his flesh and ruins his mind. Hence the worker feels himself only when he is not working; when he is working he does not feel himself. He is at home when he is not working, and not at home when he is working. His labour is therefore not voluntary but forced, it is *forced labour*. It is therefore not the satisfaction of a need but a mere *means* to satisfy needs outside itself. Its alien character is clearly demonstrated by the fact that as soon as no physical or other compulsion exists it is shunned like the plague. External labour, labour in which man alienates himself, is a labour of self-sacrifice, of mortification. Finally, the external character of labour for the worker is demonstrated by the fact that it belongs not to him but to another, and that in it he belongs not to himself but to another. Just as in religion the spontaneous activity of the human imagination, the human brain and the human heart detaches itself from the individual and reappears as the alien activity of a god or of a devil, so the activity of the worker is not his own spontaneous activity. It belongs to another, it is a loss of his self.

48 The result is that man (the worker) feels that he is acting freely only in his animal functions—eating, drinking and procreating, or at most in his dwelling and adornment—while in his human functions he is nothing more than an animal.

49 It is true that eating, drinking and procreating, etc., are also genuine human functions. However, when abstracted from other aspects of human activity and turned into final and exclusive ends, they are animal.

50 We have considered the act of estrangement of practical human activity, of labour, from two aspects: (1) the relationship of the worker to the *product of labour* as an alien object that has power over him. This relationship is at the same time the relationship to the sensuous external world, to natural objects, as an alien world confronting him in hostile opposition. (2) The relationship of labour to the *act of production* within *labour*. This relationship is the relationship of the worker to his own activity as something which is alien and does not belong to him, activity as passivity [*Leiden*], power as impotence, procreation as emasculation, the worker's *own* physical and mental energy, his personal life—for what is life but activity?—as an activity directed against himself, which is independent of him and does not belong to him. *Self-estrangement*, as compared with the estrangement of the *object* [*Sache*] mentioned above.

51 We now have to derive a third feature of *estranged labour* from the two we have already looked at.

52 Man is a species-being, not only because he practically and theoretically makes the species—both his own and those of other things—his object, but also—and this is simply another way of saying the same thing—because he looks upon himself as the present, living species, because he looks upon himself as a *universal* and therefore free being.

53 Species-life, both for man and for animals, consists physically in the fact that man, like animals, lives from inorganic nature; and because man is more universal than animals, so too is the area of inorganic nature from which he lives more universal. Just as plants, animals, stones, air, light, etc., theoretically form a part of human consciousness, partly as objects of science and partly as objects of art—his spiritual inorganic nature, his spiritual means of life, which he must first prepare before he can enjoy and digest them—so too in practice they form a part of human life and human activity. In a physical sense man lives only from these natural products, whether in the form of nourishment, heating, clothing,

shelter, etc. The universality of man manifests itself in practice in that universality which makes the whole of nature his *inorganic* body, (1) as a direct means of life and (2) as the matter, the object and the tool of his life activity. Nature is man's *inorganic body*, that is to say nature in so far as it is not the human body. Man *lives* from nature, i.e. nature is his *body*, and he must maintain a continuing dialogue with it if he is not to die. To say that man's physical and mental life is linked to nature simply means that nature is linked to itself, for man is a part of nature.

Estranged labour not only (1) estranges nature from man and (2) estranges 54
man from himself, from his own active function, from his vital activity; because of this it also estranges man from his *species*. It turns his *species-life* into a means for his individual life. Firstly it estranges species-life and individual life, and secondly it turns the latter, in its abstract form, into the purpose of the former, also in its abstract and estranged form.

For in the first place labour, *life activity*, *productive life* itself appears to 55
man only as a *means* for the satisfaction of a need, the need to preserve physical existence. But productive life is species-life. It is life-producing life. The whole character of a species, its species-character, resides in the nature of its life activity, and free conscious activity constitutes the species-character of man. Life itself appears only as a *means of life*.

The animal is immediately one with its life activity. It is not distinct from 56
that activity; it *is* that activity. Man makes his life activity itself an object of his will and consciousness. He has conscious life activity. It is not a determination with which he directly merges. Conscious life activity directly distinguishes man from animal life activity. Only because of that is he a species-being. Or rather, he is a conscious being, i.e. his own life is an object for him, only because he is a species-being. Only because of that is his activity free activity. Estranged labour reverses the relationship so that man, just because he is a conscious being, makes his life activity, his *being* [*Wesen*], a mere means for his *existence*.

The practical creation of an *objective world*, the *fashioning* of inorganic 57
nature, is proof that man is a conscious species-being, i.e. a being which treats the species as its own essential being or itself as a species-being. It is true that animals also produce. They build nests and dwellings, like the bee, the beaver, the ant, etc. But they produce only their own immediate needs or those of their young; they produce one-sidedly, while man produces universally; they produce only when

immediate physical need compels them to do so, while man produces even when he is free from physical need and truly produces only in freedom from such need; they produce only themselves, while man reproduces the whole of nature; their products belong immediately to their physical bodies, while man freely confronts his own product. Animals produce only according to the standards and needs of the species to which they belong, while man is capable of producing according to the standards of every species and of applying to each object its inherent standard; hence man also produces in accordance with the laws of beauty.

58 It is therefore in his fashioning of the objective that man really proves himself to be a *species-being*. Such production is his active species-life. Through it nature appears as *his* work and his reality. The object of labour is therefore the *objectification of the species-life of man:* for man reproduces himself not only intellectually, in his consciousness, but actively and actually, and he can therefore contemplate himself in a world he himself has created. In tearing away the object of his production from man, estranged labour therefore tears away from him his *species-life*, his true species-objectivity, and transforms his advantage over animals into the disadvantage that his inorganic body, nature, is taken from him.

59 In the same way as estranged labour reduces spontaneous and free activity to a means, it makes man's species-life a means of his physical existence.

60 Consciousness, which man has from his species, is transformed through estrangement so that species-life becomes a means for him.

61 (3) Estranged labour therefore turns *man's species-being*—both nature and his intellectual species-powers—into a being *alien* to him and a *means* of his *individual existence*. It estranges man from his own body, from nature as it exists outside him, from his spiritual essence [*Wesen*], his *human* essence.

62 (4) An immediate consequence of man's estrangement from the product of his labour, his life activity, his species-being, is the *estrangement of man from man*. When man confronts himself, he also confronts *other* men. What is true of man's relationship to his labour, to the product of his labour and to himself, is also true of his relationship to other men, and to the labour and the object of the labour of other men.

63 In general, the proposition that man is estranged from his species-being means that each man is estranged from the others and that all are estranged from man's essence.

Man's estrangement, like all relationships of man to himself, is realized and 64
expressed only in man's relationship to other men.

In the relationship of estranged labour each man therefore regards the other 65
in accordance with the standard and the situation in which he as a worker finds himself.

We started out from an economic fact, the estrangement of the worker and 66
of his production. We gave this fact conceptual form: *estranged, alienated* labour. We have analysed this concept, and in so doing merely analysed an economic fact.

Let us now go on to see how the concept of estranged, alienated labour must 67
express and present itself in reality.

If the product of labour is alien to me and confronts me as an alien power, to 68
whom does it then belong?

To a being *other* than me. 69

Who is this being? 70

The *gods*? It is true that in early times most production—e.g. temple building, 71
etc., in Egypt, India and Mexico—was in the service of the gods, just as the product belonged to the gods. But the gods alone were never the masters of labour. The same is true of *nature*. And what a paradox it would be if the more man subjugates nature through his labour and the more divine miracles are made superfluous by the miracles of industry, the more he is forced to forgo the joy of production and the enjoyment of the product out of deference to these powers.

The *alien* being to whom labour and the product of labour belong, in whose 72
service labour is performed and for whose enjoyment the product of labour is created, can be none other than *man* himself.

If the product of labour does not belong to the worker, and if it confronts him 73
as an alien power, this is only possible because it belongs to *a man other than the worker*. If his activity is a torment for him, it must provide *pleasure* and enjoyment for someone else. Not the gods, not nature, but only man himself can be this alien power over men.

Consider the above proposition that the relationship of man to himself 74
becomes *objective* and *real* for him only through his relationship to other men. If therefore he regards the product of his labour, his objectified labour, as an *alien, hostile* and powerful object which is independent of him, then his relationship to that object is such that another man—alien, hostile, powerful and independent of

him—is its master. If he relates to his own activity as unfree activity, then he relates to it as activity in the service, under the rule, coercion and yoke of another man.

75 Every self-estrangement of man from himself and nature is manifested in the relationship he sets up between other men and himself and nature. Thus religious self-estrangement is necessarily manifested in the relationship between layman and priest, or, since we are here dealing with the spiritual world, between layman and mediator, etc. In the practical, real world, self-estrangement can manifest itself only in the practical, real relationship to other men. The medium through which estrangement progresses is itself a *practical* one. So through estranged labour man not only produces his relationship to the object and to the act of production as to alien and hostile powers[1]; he also produces the relationship in which other men stand to his production and product, and the relationship in which he stands to these other men. Just as he creates his own production as a loss of reality, a punishment, and his own product as a loss, a product which does not belong to him, so he creates the domination of the non-producer over production and its product. Just as he estranges from himself his own activity, so he confers upon the stranger an activity which does not belong to him.

[...]

[1] In the original manuscript Marx wrote the word *Menschen* (men) and not *Mächten* (powers).